

**WEEKLY BUSINESS SESSION – May 27, 2026**

9:00a.m. – Anne Basker Auditorium  
600 N.W. Sixth Street, Grants Pass, OR 97526

Present: Ron A. Smith, Chair-Commissioner; Colene M. Martin, Vice-Chair-Commissioner and Gary L. Richardson, Commissioner, Nikole Guzman, Recorder

---

*These are meeting minutes only. Only text enclosed in quotation marks reports a speaker's exact words.*

---

Pursuant to notice through the media and in conformance with the Public Meeting Law, Ron A. Smith, Chair, called the meeting to order at 9:00 a.m. followed by the Pledge of Allegiance.

Items discussed were as follows:

**1. CALL MEETING TO ORDER:** Pursuant to notice through the media and in conformance with the Public Meeting Law, Ron A. Smith, Chair, called the meeting to order at 9:00 a.m.

**2. DECLARE A POTENTIAL CONFLICT OF INTEREST:**

The commissioners reserved their right to declare a potential conflict of interest.

**3. OREGON STATE MARINE BOARD TO AWARD RECIPIENTS OF LIFE SAVER AWARD**

Sheriff Dave Daniel introduced representatives from the Oregon State Marine Board and provided background regarding a February 16, 2026 rescue operation involving Gabriel Vaughn, who became separated from his rafting group near Green Wall Rapids on the Illinois River in a remote area of Josephine County. Sheriff Daniel explained that members of the private rafting community coordinated with the Josephine County Sheriff's Office Search and Rescue Division and the United States Coast Guard in efforts to locate Mr. Vaughn under difficult winter river conditions. Daniel stated that the group ultimately located Mr. Vaughn alive approximately two miles downstream from his last known location, after which he was rescued by Coast Guard helicopter and transported for medical treatment.

Sheriff Daniel thanked the rafting community members involved in the rescue effort and stated that the operation fell outside the technical capabilities normally available through the Sheriff's Office Search and Rescue program. Daniel commended the private citizens for utilizing their river expertise and experience to assist in locating and rescuing Mr. Vaughn.

Larry Warren, Director of the Oregon State Marine Board, addressed the Board and presented Oregon State Marine Board Life Saver Awards recognizing the individuals involved in the rescue operation. Warren discussed the importance of recreational boating safety and commended the recipients for their selfless actions in assisting another individual in need. Warren additionally noted that this was the second occasion he had traveled to Josephine County to recognize private citizens for lifesaving rescue efforts.

The following individuals were recognized by the Oregon State Marine Board:

Aaron Babcock  
Alex Azasi  
Nicole Smedegard  
Sean Bowen  
Andrew Morrissey  
Neil Guthrie  
Kelsey Barnes  
Aaron Edrick  
Jonathan Vaughn

Commissioners thanked the recipients, the Oregon State Marine Board, the Sheriff's Office, and Search and Rescue personnel for their work and dedication to public safety. Commissioners additionally acknowledged the dangers associated with the Illinois River and expressed appreciation for the willingness of private citizens to assist in emergency rescue efforts.

**4. ADMINISTRATIVE ACTION(S) IN CONSIDERATION OF**

**5. REQUESTS/COMMENTS FROM CITIZENS:** *(Each person will be given three (3) minutes to speak)*

**6. BOARD MAY REVIEW PUBLIC COMMENTS/QUESTIONS:**

The Board addressed public comments

**7. APPROVAL OF CONSENT CALENDAR:**

- a. Minutes (draft minutes are available for viewing in the board's office)

General Discussion – May 18, 2026

Budget Committee Meeting – May 19, 2026

Admin Workshop – May 19, 2026

Executive Session – May 19, 2026

Weekly Business Session – May 20, 2026

Budget Committee Meeting – May 21, 2026

Executive Session – May 22, 2026

Board Journal – April 2026

Commissioner Richardson made a motion to approve the Consent Calendar, seconded by Commissioner Martin. Upon roll call, Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0.

- 8. OTHER: (ORS 192.640(1))** “. . . notice shall include a list of the principal subjects anticipated to be considered at the meeting, but this requirement shall not limit the ability of a governing body to consider additional subjects.”)

**9. ANNOUNCEMENTS: MATTERS FROM COMMISSIONERS:**

Commissioner Richardson highlighted community outreach efforts being conducted by Illinois Valley Community Development Organization (IV Can Do) in support of emergency preparedness and wildfire awareness. Richardson discussed the organization's participation in the "Know Your Zone" initiative, including distribution of informational materials designed to help residents identify their evacuation zones and register for emergency alert notifications. Richardson also reviewed several assistance programs available through IV Can Do and partner organizations, including home energy assessments, smoke detector installations, air purifiers, accessibility improvements, septic system assistance, carbon monoxide monitors, and home weatherization projects for qualifying households.

Commissioner Martin expressed appreciation for IV Can Do's efforts and noted the important role that community organizations and local residents play in supporting their neighbors and improving quality of life throughout Josephine County. Chair Smith echoed those comments and discussed the value of nonprofit organizations and citizen involvement in addressing community needs and assisting residents.

Weekly Business Session adjourned at 9:14 a.m.



Nikole Guzman, Recorder